of US-trained soldiers of the Bolivian Army in October 1967). He and Raúl were strongly opposed to Fidel's attempts to reassure Americans about his motives and ideals. When Fidel told the National Press Club in Washington that 'We are against all kinds of dictators … that is why we are against communism,' his views were not shared by those closest to him.[21]

Castro himself never joined the communist party and at times had difficult relations with Moscow's supporters. Yet Raúl Castro and Che Guevara, along with other stalwarts of the revolution, notably Camilo Cienfuegos, successfully extended the grip of the PSP on the Cuban state, including its security forces. Raul and Che quickly emerged as the driving force behind the revolutionary tribunals that dispensed justice by means of executions. Hundreds of death sentences resulted. By the time Fidel travelled to the United States in April 1959 over 500 'Batistas' were estimated to have been executed.

When he came to power, Castro promised free elections. Many sympathetic to his cause attached importance to this pledge and were dismayed when elections failed to appear. They watched (and protested) at the imprisonment of domestic opponents, as criticism of the government was increasingly taken as support for the counter-revolutionaries. The counter-revolutionaries themselves – former members of the Batista regime – also contributed to this emerging cycle of repression and dissent. One incident that fuelled Castro's anger and indignation was on 4 March 1960, when a French freighter carrying Belgian munitions, *La Coubre*, blew up in Havana harbour killing over a hundred people. The circumstances remain unclear, but Castro could hardly be blamed for suspecting the hidden hand of his enemies. As violence continued, the Cuban security forces became more vigilant.

Alienated supporters of the revolution became opponents. Although counter-revolutionaries included some Batistas, their ranks were soon filled with disaffected supporters of the revolution. Between 1960 and 1962 an estimated 200,000 Cubans – many middle-class professionals and other skilled workers – left for the United States.[22] The exodus from East Germany before the erection of the Berlin Wall in August 1961 provides a striking comparison.